Committee: United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC)

Topic: The Question of Promoting Climate Justice for marginalised Communities Affected by Environmental Disasters

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Introduction

The planet is running out of time. Environmental disaster refers to a sudden, catastrophic event affecting natural circumstances that is due to human activities and natural phenomena, or both. It includes floods, wildfires, tsunamis, earthquakes and droughts, which result in devastating damage to our property, shelters, and lives. Natural disasters are highly influenced by climate change. Rising global average temperatures and sea levels intensify the very conditions that turn ordinary natural circumstances into catastrophic disasters.

Generally, people think that because environmental disasters stem from nature itself, they occur randomly and negatively affect everyone equally. However, in reality, this is far from true. Marginalised communities, which do not have the economic, social, or political power to protect themselves from any form of harm, such as low income households, racial minorities, and citizens of developing countries, consistently suffer the greatest losses.

As climate change has been aggravating exponentially since the First Industrial Revolution, environmental disasters have become more severe and frequent. In turn, the damage inflicted on marginalised communities worsened even further. What begins as an environmental issue is therefore considered a major human rights issue. Now, for the sake of Human Rights, it is time to look beyond formal equality, and consider substantive equality instead. While formal equality assumes that treating every society and individuals under the same criteria is enough, substantive equality asks much harder questions. It cares whether people are, in practice, equally safe under the system. Thus, we must concentrate on narrowing the gap in damage suffered between income groups, and achieving climate justice in developing nations.

To achieve this justice, international cooperation is strongly required. On a positive note, the global community has already been working in order to address the goal, reducing the gap between groups affected by natural disasters. From the Kyoto Protocol (1997) to the Paris Agreement (2015), global society has made huge efforts toward negotiating aimed at collective climate action. Also, many nations, including both developed and developing countries, have taken actual steps to decrease the amount of emissions and support vulnerable countries.

Still, despite these efforts, climate change driven inequality remains a pressing global issue, as marginalised communities continue to carry a disproportionate share of the damage. In addition, even with several official meetings addressing the issue, these attempts have not been enough to close that gap. Because the progress made so far remains insufficient, the international community is asked to pursue even greater, more fruitful and more productive solutions.

On this topic, three main questions must be considered. The first question asks who will actually bear the cost of recovering after the disaster. The second asks whether the measure applies the same criteria and rule to nations which are in very different situations from one another. Last but not least, the third considers whether the measure comes with realistic funding and enforcement rather than mere intention. These three points should shape every resolution, speech, POI raised in this committee, UNHRC.

Definition of Key Terms

Substantive Equality

Equality is considered one of the most fundamental concepts in sociology, and a notion that no society can do without. However, the specific meaning of equality has been subject to a variety of interpretations. Substantive equality is a relatively recent interpretation. It evaluates equality in a particular situation by first recognising the differences and treating everything outside those differences as equal. In other words, it is the equality of the things that remain after such differences are accepted and ignored. The differences that are relevant, and what will constitute the remainder which will be treated as equal, is not static.

For instance, some countries may face far greater exposure to environmental disasters that are caused by industrial activity, even though they have contributed the least to that activity. Understanding this inequality in responsibility, while ensuring equal protection and assistance beyond it, is what substantive equality requires in this case.

Climate Change

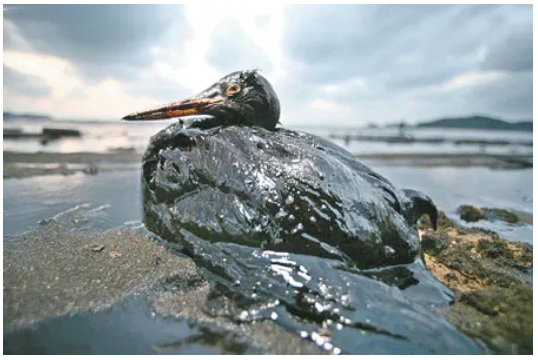
Climate change refers to a long term shift in the average climate condition system. It should be measured over a period of thirty years or more with the WMO's (World Meteorological Organisation) standard. Climate change has happened for the whole geological history, however today's rate of change is unprecedented. Warming occurs roughly ten times faster than natural warming seen at the last period of ice age. This was driven largely by human activities since the First Industrial Revolution.

Climate Justice

Climate justice is defined as an approach to concern climate change not merely as a natural issue, but as a social, ethical, and human-related issue. It recognises that the cause and effects of climate change are distributed unequally, as those nations and communities that have least contributed to emissions often suffer the most severe consequences. Climate justice therefore urges globally for narrowing this gap, both within societies and between nations, as a matter of Human Rights.

Environmental Disaster

Environmental disaster is a sudden catastrophic event affecting the natural environment that is triggered by human activities. Notable examples include the Chernobyl Nuclear Disaster (1986) and South Korea Taean Oil Spill Incident (2007). Strictly defined, this distinguishes it from a 'natural disaster,' which arises from pure natural processes with no direct human influence. However, the environmental disaster is often used more broadly to cover the meaning of natural disasters as well.



Oil-covered grebe, Taean oil spill, Korea Federation for Environmental Movements (KFEM, 2007)

Marginalised Community

A marginalised community is a social group composed of individuals that lack the economic, social, or political power needed to live a decent life. In the context of climate change, this includes low income families, racial minorities, and citizens in developing nations, who often lack the ability to respond from environmental disasters. The main reason is that these group members are often without financial resources and infrastructure necessary to prepare for, withstand or recover from the disasters.

Common but Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR)

Common But Differentiated Responsibilities, or CBDR, is a principle in international environmental law which states that even if all nations share a common responsibility to protect the global environment, the level of such responsibility will vary based on their historic contribution and present capacities. This principle was first suggested in the 1992 Rio Declaration and has been an important element of the UNFCCC (United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change) —

specifically mentioned in Article 3(1) and Article 4(1) of the UNFCCC — and the 1997 Kyoto Protocol since then.



The UNFCCC was signed at the 1992 'Earth Summit' in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. Photo: UN Photo/Michos Tzovaras

Background Information

Definition and Background of Climate Change

Climate Change refers to a long-term shift in the average conditions of the climate system. According to WMO (World Meteorological Organisation), climate change is defined as the change in the average value of weather measured over thirty years or more, statistically significant variability. Although the climate has changed throughout geological history, the change observed today is unlike anything before it. Specifically, it is 10 times faster than the natural warming in the end of ice age, and CO2 increases 250 times faster than during the period. And because of its global reach and rapid pace, climate change is causing serious damage. It affects not only the climate itself, but also to whole ecosystems, including humans.

The acceleration of climate change after the Industrial Revolution is largely the result of human activity. After the second World War, the material civilisation that humans built through industrialisation came at the cost of over-exploiting the natural resources. According to the study of Steffen et al (2015), between 1950 and 2010, as the global population tripled and the world's real GDP (Gross Domestic Product) increased roughly seven times, the climate crisis worsened. Greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption rose sharply, and the destruction of terrestrial ecosystems advanced swiftly.

At the moment, the state of climate change is critical. According to the WMO (World Meteorological Organization) annual report, the eleven-year period, from 2015 to 2025, was the warmest year ever recorded. 2025 alone, reached approximately 1.43 °C above the pre-industrial period's average temperature. This stresses that climate change is no longer a far future risk, but a present crisis, which requires immediate action of international society.

The impact of climate change on modern society is enormous. It causes droughts, wildfires, heavy rainfall, and even makes species exposed to disease. In addition, it also affects biodiversity. IPBES (Intergovernmental Science-policy Platform on Biodiversity and Ecosystem Service) predicts that more than a million species will go extinct, and half of them will lose their habitat they need to survive in the long term. As a result, an increasingly extreme climate is taking away the homes of the vulnerable, triggering climate refugees, political and economic damage.

Definition of Climate Justice

Basically, the effects of climate change are not distributed equally across nations. A clear illustration of this can be found in the Maldives and Tuvalu, low-lying island nations that account for a negligible amount of carbon emissions, yet face disastrous threats from rising sea levels. Hence, it stresses the importance of 'Climate Justice.' Climate justice is an approach to frame climate change not just as an environmental issue, but also as a social and ethical issue.



cardboard sign reading "Climate Justice Now" (Environmental Justice Foundation, 2021)

Climate justice states that developed countries have responsibility to compensate and support the developing countries and underdeveloped countries suffering from climate change, and take more responsibility in the global effort promoting carbon neutrality for the sake of equality. In other words, climate justice aims for 'substantive equality' which recognises that countries have contributed differently to the current climate crisis, and so they should have differentiated responsibility in solving climate change issues.

Climate justice has four key dimensions: procedural, distributive, recognition, and intergenerational (Newell et al., 2021). Procedural justice concerns the fairness of decision-making processes, including equitable access to information and meaningful participation. Distributive justice cares about fair sharing of climate change's burdens. In other words, it is about how costs and benefits are allocated across time and space, and who utilises certain resources. Recognition justice concentrates on rights for marginalised communities, while recognising the difference of circumstances that each society faces. Lastly, with these mentioned three justices, intergenerational justice aims to protect future generations from the damaging effects caused by climate change.

Historical Background of Climate Justice Efforts

The notion of climate justice originated from the Environmental Justice movement in the United States in the 1980s. The term “Climate Justice” began to be used widely following the publication of a 1999 report by CorpWatch, an NGO (Non-government Organisation). The concept of climate justice became profoundly established at the international level with the first Climate Justice Summits, held alongside COP6 (Conference of Parties 6) of the UNFCCC (United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change), which mainly gave an opportunity to developing and underdeveloped countries to voice their own perspectives and demands.



Debating UNFCCC Members (UNFCCC, 2020)

Over time, the international community tried to establish clearer standards for climate justice. This effort was first formalised in 2002 with the Bali Principles of Climate Justice. It was one of the first documents to define climate change as a human rights issue. Few years later, in 2009, COP15 (Conference of Parties 15) triggered frustration among developing countries, since the debate was dominated by developed countries. This showed why climate justice remained a critical issue. The Paris Agreement (2015) was written on the CBDR (Common But Differentiated Responsibilities) principle, which had been mentioned in the Kyoto Protocol.

Major Agreements

In December of 1997, the third Conference of the Parties (COP3) to the UNFCCC, held in Kyoto of Japan, adopted the Kyoto Protocol. It entered into force in 2005, with its first commitment period running from 2008 to 2012. Reduction targets were set only for 38 developed nations that accounted for 55% of industrial emissions, while developing nations (e.g., Mexico, China, and India) were exempted. Under the treaty, Annex I Parties were required to reduce their emissions by an average of 5.2% compared to 1990 levels, with individual targets such as 8% for the European Union, 7% for the United States, and 6% for Japan.

To assist their member states in achieving these objectives in an efficient manner, the Protocol established the Kyoto Mechanisms. The Kyoto Mechanisms include Joint Implementation, the Clean Development Mechanism, and Emissions Trading. The effectiveness of the treaty, however, greatly diminished due to the refusal of the United States to ratify the treaty, Canada's withdrawal in 2011, and the absence of emerging major emitters within the binding commitment.



Villagers using a solar cooker for a communal meal, illustrating clean energy technology referenced in UNFCCC's overview of the Kyoto Mechanisms (UNFCCC Photo/Jiang Wei, n.d.)

The Paris Agreement was adopted on December 12, 2015, at COP21 in Paris. The treaty entered into force on November 4, 2016. In contrast to the Kyoto Protocol, which lost a major emitter and failed to secure an extension, it was successfully selected unanimously by 195 member states. The UN Secretary-General at the time Ban Ki-Moon lobbied intensively and brought on board the 55 states responsible for more than 55% of global emissions and succeeded in getting ratification from the top emitters including the U.S., China, and the EU.

To be more specific on this, the Paris Agreement covers 195 parties representing 95.7% of global emissions. The Agreement set the goal of keeping global temperature rise well below 2°C above pre-industrial levels, while pursuing efforts to limit it to 1.5°C. The NDC (the Nationally Determined Contribution) of each country is set under the Paris Agreement, stating that the agreement will be revised every five years through the Global Stocktake.



Ban Ki-moon, Laurent Fabius, and François Hollande celebrate the adoption of the Paris Agreement at COP21 (COP21, 2015)

Still, the implementation of the Paris Agreement has not been totally seamless since then. To give an example of the United States, which has the greatest responsibility and power on this issue, the first Trump administration of the U.S. pulled out of it in 2017, and left officially in 2020. While they joined back during the presidency of Biden in 2021, they pulled out once again in 2025, after the start of the Second Trump administration. Although, all other parties (around 195, due to the withdrawal of the U.S.) remain committed to the agreement.

While the Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement both have the same goals, there were notable differences in perspective of obligations between them**.** The Paris Agreement only binds countries to submit and report to self-set NDCs, while Kyoto legally binds countries to their target number. Also, Kyoto had no mechanism to automatically strengthen targets, however, Paris does require each new NDC to be more ambitious than the past.

Marginalised Communities Affected by Environmental Disasters

Environmental disasters do not destroy all communities equally. While natural disasters — such as flood, wildfire, tsunami — occur completely randomly, the scale of the damage they inflict is not. With these circumstances, the marginalised communities suffer at a higher rate, as they have limited access to resources vital for prevention and recovery. In this sense, environmental disasters should not be defined only as natural phenomena, but as a matter of modern global society.

There are mainly four types of marginalised societies affected by environmental disasters. The first, perhaps the most fundamental, form of disparity is economic. Low-income communities often face the lack of financial capacity to adapt to climate change, leaving them unfairly exposed to its backlash. For example, in Hong Kong, residents of "Cage Homes," which is a subdivided apartment, often cannot afford air conditioning. Hong Kong Observatory data cited in CNN in 2025 reveals the number of hot days (over 33°C) rose from '6' in 2004 to '52' in 2024. A 2024 survey by the Society for Community Organisation (SoCO) also found that 83% of subdivided-flat residents experienced sleep problems during the summer heat. Therefore, their situation will only worsen as time goes on.



Subdivided apartments in Hong Kong, (Newsweek, 2023)

Secondly, racism is also an influential factor that causes the marginalised community after the disasters. Due to this environmental-racism, which refers to the disproportionate load of climate effect placed on racial, minority, or low-income communities, natural hazards and resources are distributed very unequally along racial lines. This can be seen in the United States, where people of colour are one of those most affected. A 2019 study published in PNAS (Proceedings of the National Academy

of Science) has found that Hispanics and African-Americans breathe 63% and 56% more polluted than they make respectively. Throughout the country, people of colour are exposed to much higher amounts of air pollutants such as PM 2.5 (Particulate Matter 2.5), regardless of location or income level.

From a macro perspective, beyond individual nations, the disparity is also seen between entire states. Specifically, countries that have influenced the least to global carbon emissions often suffer the most critical aftereffects of changes of climate. In the Philippines, which barely contributes to global carbon emissions, yet are damaged from the world's most frequent and destructive typhoons. Also for Indonesia, its territory is sinking due to rising sea levels triggered by climate change, prompting the government to even discuss relocating its capital.

Meanwhile, the damage that is caused by disasters in developed countries is pretty manageable. For instance, Korea often meets with serious disasters causing significant casualties and economical damage. However, with its budget and well-structured response system, it is able to reconstruct the country within a short term, far faster than developing nations. This contrast between responsibility and impact clearly demonstrates the injustice underlying the global climate crisis.

Lastly, the disparity extends across time, weighing mostly on future generations. Since climate change predictions grow increasingly grim, young people are experiencing an escalating sense of anxiety and helplessness, known as "Climate Anxiety." Majeed and Lee (2017) have shown that there are meaningful correlations between climate change indicators and worsening individuals' psychological health. Given that youth is still at a profound stage of psychological development, they are vulnerable to stress. Additionally, not just limited to caring for their mental health, we also have to focus on the fact that future climate will fully impact the livelihoods of youths, including those who depend on agriculture.

Possible solutions

Differentiating Responsibility Between Developed and Developing nations

With the perspective of substantive equality, Developed nations should have more responsibility since they have contributed significantly on emission issues, and also have far greater financial capacity. Accordingly, member states can call for more specified action to achieve differentiated financial responsibility on the issue of climate change. The climate finance architecture applies largely uniform expectations to countries with different levels of emissions and financial capacities so far. And as mentioned above, many attempts have failed to achieve substantive equality.

This process should include a clear formula for distributing each member states' fair share, based on past emissions and current GDP. It should set fixed funding targets instead of vague long-term goals. In addition, a review mechanism should be considered in the process, so contribution levels can be adjusted every few years as economics change. Without these specific details, the solution will repeat the failure of Kyoto and Paris, where pledges existed but actions did not.

Establishing Global Fund with Targeted Delivery

Supporting systems, especially in financial methods, should stay open to every member state, without exception. But the money itself should reach those who need it most first based on the standards such as income level, disaster exposure and existing infrastructure gaps. By maintaining access universal but delivery targeted specifically, the fund may avoid the appearance of favouritism, while still directing resources where they are truly needed.

The funding system should suggest clear eligibility guidelines with measurable vulnerability indicators such as income level, disaster exposure, and existing infrastructure gaps. Allowing direct applications from local governments, city districts, or community organisations can be a better way to make the process more fair and effective. Not only that but it should also include a simplified application process, while keeping thorough standards for determining who receives aid.

Strengthening Cooperation Through Regional Bodies

Every region faces different climate risks. Simple top-down approach, coordinated solely through the United Nations cannot respond immediately to all of these differences. Regional international bodies (e.g., the ASEAN, the African Union, and the EU) are often closer to the problem physically and institutionally. With this knowledge, this solution calls for dedicated support from regional international bodies for the sake of efficiency.

This cooperation may contain the establishment of early warning systems and mutual aid/rescue mechanisms between neighboring nations. Since these countries are geographically close to one another, such systems will provide much quicker assistance than what could be offered if the United Nations assistance was sought out. It is only logical that regional institutions and societies are in a position to provide such assistance.

Legal Protections for Climate Refugees

As noted uncountably above, the compounding impacts of human activity and climate change continue to escalate. According to the UNHCR (United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees), the number of nations affected by extreme climate risks will increase from 3 to 65 by 2040. It goes without saying that the amount of people who are vulnerable to climate-induced displacement will increase exponentially.

This solution requires the formal incorporation of indigenous and local community members in the development of disaster response plans at both the national and regional levels. They should not just be there for an advisory role, but they should be involved as co-designers who suggest decisions. There should be funds allocated to record traditional ecological knowledge in addition to means through which traditional ecological knowledge can be integrated with technological advances.

Major parties involved

UNFCCC (United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change)

The UNFCCC is the central international treaty and institutional framework for change negotiations at the global level. It was established at the 1992 Rio Earth Summit, serving as the parent body within which the Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement have been ratified. The UNFCCC secretariat organises Conference of the Parties (COP), facilitates negotiations among member states, and ensures them to fulfill their obligations. Its role is particularly central to climate justice discussions, as it is the main forum where developing countries can voice their complaints regarding the CBDR principle.

EU (European Union)

The European Union has positioned itself as a world leader when it comes to climate change governance since it is one of the first economies to have adopted binding and economy-wide emissions reduction targets. In its European Green Deal strategy, the EU intends to ensure that the region is climate neutral by the year 2050, committing huge amounts of money to help developing countries using strategies like the Global Climate Change Alliance. The EU has always called on developed countries to show strong commitment to CBDR principles during UNFCCC negotiations. Nevertheless, the EU is often criticised for its CBAM (Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism) that is claimed to place decarbonisation costs on exporters from the Global South.

United States of America

Following the inauguration of the second Trump administration in early 2025, the United States of America (the U.S.) has adopted an increasingly hostile attitude toward climate policy. President Trump has been known to be highly critical of the climate agenda, even going as far as to refer to climate change as a “con job.” Based on this stance, the current administration has left the Paris Agreement for the second time and plans to leave the UNFCCC and the IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change).



Donald Trump addressing the UN general assembly, where he called the climate crisis 'the greatest con job', New York, (Angelina Katsanis/AP, 2025)

Although the United States is no longer a former member of the UNHRC since February 2025, it remains highly influential over all member states as the world's largest historical emitter and a leading global political and economic power.

French Republic

France is one of the EU's most vocal countries with regard to climate justice in Europe, particularly through being the host of the historic COP21 talks where the Paris Agreement was reached in 2015. Domestically, France's energy policy includes heavy reliance on nuclear energy in tandem with renewables as part of a commitment to achieve carbon neutrality by 2050. Internationally, France finds itself to be one of the largest contributors to the Green Climate Fund, which allocates resources for adapting and mitigating emissions in developing countries. France is far from immune to criticism, both internally and externally, with regard to its slow transition and equitable distribution of CBAM's impact.

France aims to advocate for stronger financial contribution by the developed world to the Green Climate Fund, while seeking climate policies that are ambitious and fair to developing countries.

United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland

Alongside its European neighbours, the United Kingdom is acting as a pioneer of the climate legislation, becoming the first country to bind future governments to reducing carbon emissions via the Climate Change Act of 2008. The United Kingdom went ahead to host the COP26 summit in 2021 and assisted in securing the first mention of phasing down fossil fuels in any international climate agreement.

After formally quitting the EU in January 2020, the United Kingdom started conducting climate diplomacy by itself. In 2025, the United Kingdom announced its own plan called 'CB6 (Carbon Budget 6),' aiming for a 78% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions compared to 1990 levels. To be more specific on this, the plan is a statutory requirement under article 14 of 'Climate Change Act 2008' and serves as the third and final iteration, following 2021 'Net Zero Strategy' and the 2023 'Carbon Budget Delivery Plan (CBDP)'. According to the plan, the government's Climate Change Committee (CCC) will serve as the oversight body, evaluating feasibility and compliance of the government's climate plan.

The United Kingdom has to take the lead in shaping the discourse by aligning the environment with the economy and jobs, hence turning decarbonisation into an issue that is not just a challenge, but an opportunity for the nation.

People's Republic of China

As the world's largest greenhouse emitter, China occupies a uniquely complex position in the climate justice debate. Basically, China is responsible for roughly 30% of global emissions according to the UNEP's Emissions Gap Report. Nevertheless, China has actively cooperated in global climate efforts. At the UN Climate Summit in September 2025, President Xi Jinping of China made an unprecedented declaration on emissions targets, later formalised in the government's 2035 NDC to the UNFCCC. He presented that China will seek to reduce its carbon footprint by between 7 to 10% below the peak year by 2035, with the aim of increasing the proportion of non-fossil fuel consumption to above 30% and wind and solar generation capacity to be six times higher that in 2020.



Chinese President Xi Jinping delivers a video speech at the UN Climate Summit (AFP/Yonhap, 2025)

As the world's manufacturing hub, China is highly dependent on industrial activity, which constituted about 36.5% of the Chinese GDP in 2024, almost twice the proportion that is observed in most developed nations like the United States and the United Kingdom. The high dependency on industry implies that there will be a large volume of greenhouse gas emissions that cannot easily be avoided. Therefore, China must be very careful in its pursuit of climate pledges to ensure that decarbonisation does not undermine the industrial foundation of its economic growth.

Russian Federation

Russia is one of the biggest countries in terms of production and exports of fossil fuels in the world, so it is in a defensive position regarding the issue of climate justice. The fossil fuels play an important role in the economy of the country as the oil and gas revenues collected from them constituted approximately 30% of the budget revenues of the federation in 2023 to 2024 and 20% of its GDP. At the same time, the fossil fuel industry constitutes about 60% of the total export revenue of Russia.

Even though the government of Russia has pledged to achieve carbon neutrality by 2060, its plans up to 2035 year are focused on continuation of the current policies without any need for

reducing the carbon-dioxide emissions and its strategy in 2024 calls for a future of fossil fuels dominance with coal being ten times more important than wind and solar energy.

Due to the economic decline caused by the Russia-Ukraine war, Russia should prioritise protecting its fossil export economy. Russia must care when binding agreements as these would affect the industry that underpins its national wealth.

Germany

Germany has long been regarded as an international model of environmental leadership because of its Energiewende, the ambitious transition away from the reliance on fossil fuels and nuclear power to renewable energy sources. Germany's commitment to climate neutrality by 2045 is binding in terms of national legislation and by 2025, it managed to reduce greenhouse gas emissions by 48% compared to the level of 1990s while generating over 60% of its power from renewables.

Nevertheless, despite the final shutdown of nuclear power plants in 2023, Germany still depends on coal more than other European countries do, and it does not plan to quit using coal until 2038. Although the coalition government established in 2025 agreed to stick to previous commitments, it has shown no enthusiasm about raising ambitions regarding climate protection. Caring that, Germany should promote strong collective climate commitments and financial support of developing nations, while defending its competitiveness and energy security.

Republic of India

Interestingly, despite being the most populated country and third-highest emitter in the world, India has been very adamant about its CBDR policy. In March 2026, India adopted its NDC 3.0 (2031 to 2035), aiming for 47% reduction in emissions intensity, 60% capacity of non-fossil fuels, and reaching net zero emissions by 2070. Even though India has low per capita emissions, it is predicted to be the highest emitter by 2035.

As a leader of developing nations, India has to participate actively in the global effort to cut down, but only under the condition that this can happen only through the provision of proper finances and technology and lifting IP constraints imposed by developed nations.

Philippines

The Philippines stands as the most climate vulnerable nation. Geographically, located along the Pacific typhoon belt, the country endured 371 extreme weather events between 1998 and 2024, resulting in over 27,500 deaths and more than 35 billion US dollars in economic losses. To emphasise the seriousness, in November 2024 alone, 6 typhoons struck within just 30 days, causing 13 million victims and over 170 casualties.



A flooded street in Isabela Province, northern Luzon, Philippines, caused by Typhoon Toraji (AP/Yonhap, 2024)

Climate scientists attribute the growing intensity of these storms to rising sea temperature, which leads to an increase in moisture in the air. The IPCC has said with “high confidence” that the effects of climate change would result in further intensification of such typhoons, and experts state that if the temperature on Earth increases by 2.6 °C compared to pre-industrial levels, then the probability of creation of the storms would be increased by 40%.

The Philippines must press developed nations and its regional neighbors to deliver on climate finance and strengthen the loss and damage fund. Additionally, as one of the nations least responsible for global emissions yet most affected by climate change’s consequences, the Philippines should insist that such countries which are most responsible for climate change support those suffering the greatest harm like the Philippines.

South Africa

According to the United States Agency for International Development (USAID), South Africa is the 15th largest country that emits greenhouse gas, with roughly 85% of its electricity generated from coal, a sector that employs over 100,000 people. On the other hand, South Africa is also affected by a warming climate firsthand. Recently, in 2026, extreme floods in southern region of Africa, worsened due to climate change, led to the shutting down of the iconic Kruger National Park in South Africa and damages that would cost millions of dollars to fix.

In order to address the contradiction, South Africa came up with the Just Energy Transition Partnership (JETP) at COP26, which got approximately 12.8 billion US dollars in global financing for transitioning from coal without harming the affected employees. Regarding that, South Africa needs to advocate for the concept of 'Just Transition,' whereby developed nations are supposed to support with sufficient resources for decarbonisation without causing poverty or unemployment.

Timeline Of Events

Date	Description of Event
Environmental Justice Movement, 1980s	The notion of climate justice originates from the Environmental Justice movement in the United States with the recognition of marginalised communities.
Kyoto Protocol, 1997	The Kyoto Protocol is adopted by the UNFCCC, establishing the principle of Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and assigning binding emissions reduction targets primarily to developed nations. It officially came into effect in 2005.
CorpWatch Report, 1999	The non-government organisation called CorpWatch publishes a report titled "Greenhouse Gangsters vs. Climate Justice," which holds major petroleum companies accountable for denying, delaying, and confusing people about the climate crisis while insisting that industrialised nations should lead the transition to sustainable energy. This report popularised the term "Climate Justice."
First Climate Justice Summits, 2000	Held alongside COP6, it allowed developing nations to voice their climate concerns and demands.
Bali Principles of Climate Justice, 2002	The international community sets clearer standards for climate justice, producing one of the first documents to frame climate change as a Human Rights issue.
2009 United Nations Climate Change Conference COP15 (Conference of the Parties	The United Nations Climate Change Conference in Copenhagen is held, aiming to secure a

15), 2009	binding successor to the Kyoto Protocol. However, the conference sparks frustration among developing nations and ultimately fails to achieve an objective.
2011 United Nations Climate Change Conference COP17 (Conference of the Parties 18), 2011	The conference, held in Durban of South Africa, produces the "Durban Platform," an agreement to establish a new legally binding climate treaty by 2015, to take effect from 2020, that would include all major emitters, such as developing nations like China and India as well as countries that had rejected the Kyoto Protocol, including the United States. This laid the foundation for the Paris Agreement adopted at COP21.
2012 United Nations Climate Change Conference COP18 (Conference of the Parties 18), 2012	Concluding with the "Doha Climate Gateway," the summit takes the Kyoto Protocol into the year 2020 and lays the foundation for an entirely new climate agreement beyond 2020, all the while negotiating financial assistance for the developing countries.
Paris Agreement, 2015	Adopted at COP21, the agreement sets a goal of limiting global warming to weel below 2 °C, replacing Kyoto's top-down approach with self-determined targets from all member states.

UN Involvement, Resolutions, Treaties and Events

- United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, 9 May 1992 (Rio Earth Summit)

  The UNFCCC is the central treaty and institutional framework for global climate negotiations. It serves as the parent treaty to both the 1997 Kyoto Protocol, and the 2015 Paris Agreement, and is still the chief platform where developing countries bring up their grievances regarding the CBDR-RC principle.

- The Kyoto Protocol, 11 December 1997

  Adopted at COP3, this UNFCCC amendment suggested binding emissions targets only on 38 developed member states, averaging a 5.2% cut below 1990 levels. It included market mechanisms but proved ineffective once the United States rejected ratification and Canada pulled out of it in 2011.

- The Paris Agreement, 12 December 2015

  The Paris Agreement is adopted by 195 countries at COP21 and binds 197 parties responsible for 95.7% of global emissions. Every country sets its NDC which is reviewed every five years according to the principle of transparency but not sanctions.

- United Nations General Assembly Resolution 76/300, 28 July 2022 (A/RES/76/300)

  The United Nations General Assembly officially acknowledged the right of everyone to a clean, healthy, and sustainable environment as a universal human right through a vote of 161 member states. This gave climate justice a ‘Human Rights’ Basis.

- Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction, 18 March 2015

  The framework targets aimed at reducing casualties, impacted populations, and economic losses from disasters by 2030, stressing the importance of helping disaster-prone developing countries.

- Loss and Damage Fund (COP27/28), 20 November 2022

  The establishment of a fund for compensation of affected countries was agreed upon by all parties and initiated during COP28 in 2023. However, the funding is still significantly lacking.

- United Nations General Assembly Resolution 77/276, 29 March 2023 (A/RES/77/276)

  With Vanuatu leading and co-sponsored by 105 states, the resolution passed through a process of consensus. The resolution called on the International Court of Justice (ICJ) to give its opinion concerning states' legal obligations regarding climate change and the responsibility of the states in cases where the emissions from them caused any form of damage.

Brief Reminder

The UNHRC exists to promote and secure ‘Human Rights’ as its name suggests. This means that UNHRC does not set emissions targets or negotiate climate policy. Instead, the committee should focus on how environmental disasters threaten the rights of marginalised communities, such as the rights to life, health, and housing. At the same time, delegates should also concentrate on how financial responsibility should be distributed under the principle of CBDR and Substantive equality.

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